

Texas

The Lone Star State — place, people, and one hard question.

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GEOGRAPHIC ORIENTATION

Texas at a glance

2nd

largest U.S. state by area, after Alaska

Austin

the capital, in the Texas Hill Country

30 million+

people live here, and the number is still growing

PHYSICAL GEOGRAPHY AND CLIMATE

Three landscapes, three kinds of weather

The wet east

Pine woods and the Gulf coast get heavy rain. Summers are hot and humid, and hurricanes can reach the shore.

Hills and plains

The Hill Country rolls between rivers. Winters are usually mild, but storms and sudden cold can still arrive.

The dry west

Big Bend holds desert, canyons, and mountains. Days are very hot, nights can be cold, and water is scarce.

HISTORY

How Texas became Texas

First nations

Caddo, Comanche, Apache, and coastal peoples lived here for centuries.

Spain and Mexico

Missions came first. Later, Texas was a region of Mexico.

1836

Texas became an independent republic after the revolution.

1845

The republic joined the United States as the 28th state.

1901

Oil at Spindletop changed the towns, the jobs, and the future.

CULTURAL IDENTITY

Many stories under one star

A place shaped by more than one people

Many nations knew this land long before any flag. Spanish and Mexican families then built towns, ranches, and a Tejano culture that is still part of daily life. Later came Anglo settlers, African Americans, and European immigrants, including Czechs and Germans. The **Lone Star** is one symbol. The culture was never only one story.

ECONOMY AND INDUSTRY

What keeps Texas working

Energy

Texas produces oil and natural gas, and it also leads the United States in wind power. Energy is a strength and a responsibility.

Cities of ideas

Austin builds technology. Houston runs one of the busiest ports in the country and the Johnson Space Center, home of NASA.

Land and cattle

Cotton and cattle still matter. Ranches and farms connect today’s economy with the older picture of Texas.

Cities, countryside, and new neighbors

A large state that keeps growing

Texas is home to **more than 30 million** people. Houston, Dallas, San Antonio, and Austin are huge cities, while long stretches of the state are still ranches and small towns. About two in five residents are Hispanic or Latino. Many others are White, Black, or Asian. People move here for work, so neighborhoods, schools, and languages keep changing.

A CURRENT CHALLENGE

When a winter storm stopped the power

What happened

In February 2021, extreme cold froze equipment across Texas. Millions of homes lost electricity and heat. Most of the state's power is run by its own grid, ERCOT, not by the national networks.

A fair next step

Some people want Texas to keep an independent grid. Others want stronger links to neighboring states. A practical step, supported by later reviews, is to prepare plants and fuel lines for freezing weather.

EVIDENCE

Where these facts come from

Geography · History · Economy · Society

- U.S. Census Bureau — population size and the mix of communities
- Texas State Historical Association — the republic, statehood in 1845, and Spindletop
- National Weather Service — climate regions and the February 2021 winter storm
- ERCOT public reports — how most of the Texas electricity grid is organized



Thank you

Ask me one question: a place, a date, or the winter storm.

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